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ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 101: Traditional African Theatre - Festival, Ritual and Performance

Read African festival theatre as a complete performance system, not as folklore

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

THA 101 is where the department teaches you that African theatre did not begin with a written script. This pack explains festival theatre as a total performance event - space, audience, music, costume, masquerade and participation - and shows you how to describe a performance you have witnessed with precision instead of vague praise.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define traditional African theatre and distinguish it from written dramatic literature.
- Analyse a festival performance using space, audience, performer, music, costume and participation.
- Explain how ritual structure shapes the organisation of an African festival.
- Describe the masquerade tradition without treating it as mere entertainment.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What counts as traditional African theatre

Traditional theatre is performance made by a community, for that community, in a form inherited and adapted rather than written down by a single author.

- The performance is usually tied to a calendar, a rite of passage or a season, not to a ticketed evening.
- Text may be minimal; meaning is carried by movement, music, mask, costume and audience response.
- There is no sharp line between performers and spectators: the community participates.
- The performance often has a social function - purification, harvest thanksgiving, initiation, conflict resolution.

- Continuity comes from apprenticeship and participation, not from published scripts.

> **Avoid two mistakes**
> Do not treat African festival theatre as primitive entertainment, and do not romanticise it as untouched tradition. It changes with its community and has always absorbed new elements.

Festival as total theatre

Total theatre means every performance element carries meaning at once.

- Space: the market square, shrine, compound or village green is the stage, and its meaning changes the performance.
- Music: drums and song cue entrances, control tempo and mark transitions.
- Costume and mask: they identify status, spirit or character, and may transform the wearer.
- Movement and dance: patterned movement carries narrative and community identity.
- Audience: response, chorus and participation complete the performance.
- Time: festivals often run for days, so duration itself is part of the form.

Writing about a performance

Assessment rewards specific observation. Use this structure for any performance report.

1. State what you saw, where and on what occasion.
2. Describe the performance space and how it was used.
3. Identify performers, costumes and masks, and what each communicated.
4. Analyse music and movement as structural devices, not decoration.
5. Describe audience participation and how it shaped the event.
6. Evaluate the performance's social purpose and your evidence for that claim.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 101

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 101 Traditional African Theatre (3 credits) described as non-written drama and festival-derived theatre in various African communities
- Emphasis on theatre "evolving from the festival in its various contexts and settings"
- No separate film-track foundation course listed at 100 level in this snapshot

What changed: The 2018 page frames the course almost entirely around festival and community contexts.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 101 Traditional African Theatre, 3 credits, first semester, 100 level
- Course numbering: first digit = year, middle digits = stress area, last digits = serial
- Companion 100-level courses appear: THA 111, 131, 151, 153, 161, 112, 122, 132, 142, 152, 162

What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 122, THA 153 and THA 161 (Participation Orientation, 2 credits), which do not appear in the 2018 description.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- THA 101 remains the 100-level foundation in history and comparative theatre
- Department is now styled Theatre and Film Studies, so 100-level cohorts may take media-facing companions
- Confirm whether THA 161 Participation Orientation is still required in your own registration

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is traditional African theatre often described as total theatre?

Answer: Because music, dance, costume, mask, space and audience participation operate together as one performance system rather than as separate additions.

2. Give two social functions of a festival performance.

Answer: Harvest thanksgiving and rite-of-passage initiation; purification and conflict resolution are also common.

3. What is the danger of treating masquerade as mere entertainment?

Answer: It removes the spiritual, judicial and social meanings the masquerade carries for the community, producing a shallow and inaccurate account.

4. How does the performance space shape meaning?

Answer: A shrine, market square or compound carries its own associations and determines sightlines, participation and the intimacy of the event.

5. Name three elements you would describe in a performance report.

Answer: The space, the costumes and masks, and the music or movement patterns.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write definitions of traditional theatre, ritual and festival in your own words.
- [ ] Attend or watch a recorded Nigerian festival performance and take structured notes.
- [ ] Draw a diagram of the performance space and annotate how it was used.
- [ ] Identify three ways the audience participated.
- [ ] Write a 300-word performance description with evidence for each claim.
- [ ] Read one article on African festival theatre and note its main argument.
- [ ] Take your performance report to a senior colleague for feedback.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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